EPILOGUE

John Kennedy and Nikita Khrushchev managed to avoid nuclear war after making almost every mistake conceivable and every step imaginable to cause it. But they did not step into the traps so masterfully created by themselves because they did not believe they could win a nuclear war, nor were they prepared to pay a price for such a victory. It is hard to imagine what the outcome of the Cuban crisis might have been if the two leaders had a more cavalier attitude toward the nuclear arms.

Both men departed the political scene soon after the events described in this book. A year after the official end of the Cuban missile crisis, Kennedy was dead, assassinated on a trip to Dallas, not to any foreign land, on November 22, 1963. Khrushchev, who called his tragic death "a heavy blow to all people who hold dear the cause of peace and Soviet-American cooperation," was removed from power not by foreign troops, but by his formerly sycophantic underlings on October 14, 1964, two years to the day after the American U-2 discovered the Soviet missiles in Cuba.[1]

Whether winners or losers in the eyes of the world, the two leaders left an enduring common legacy not limited to the terror and hard lessons of the Cuban missile crisis. With the signing in August 1963 of the partial nuclear test-ban treaty, Kennedy and Khrushchev saved the world a second time by drastically limiting radioactive fallout, which threatened life on this planet